

Many ticker symbols are simply the equivalent of vanity license plates. They are abbreviations of the name or the initials of the company: OAK for Oak Industries, MAN for Manpower, IGT for International Game Technology. Some are more ingenious: BSMT for Filene's Basement and RAZR for American Safety Razor. Entrepreneurs often use their first names to create vanity tickers: ELY for Callaway Golf, CARL for Karcher Enterprises.

Then we move from prose to poetry. These ticker symbols refer to the company's line of business, but metaphorically.

ROCK	Gibraltar Steel
ZEUS	Olympic Steel
LODE	Comstock Bank
HAMS	Smithfield Companies
JAVA	Mr. Coffee
RARE	Bugaboo Creek Steak House
NOSH	Kineret Acquisition (now Hain Food)
FOTO	Seattle Filmworks
FON	Sprint Corporation
BLUD	Immucor
BID	Sotheby's
DOSE	Choice Drug Systems

Two special favorites of mine:

GAIT	Langer Biomechanics, a researcher into foot and limb biomechanics
BAK	Clinicorp, an owner of chiropractic centers